

The Dangers of AI: Deepfakes and Beyond

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February 10, 2026

Abstract

This essay examines governance failures around AI-generated deepfakes with an emphasis on non-consensual intimate imagery and its effects on individuals, society and what this means for governance. This is an essay of research meeting rage. Reports are drawn from Panorama Global and UN Women as well as researchers Natalie Shapira and Weiyan Shi. It argues about the fragility of current legal frameworks and inadequate to fast paced technological changes and the dangers it presents. This essay calls for harm assessments, consent frameworks and policies around AI and prosecution.

Keywords: deepfakes, AI governance, AI safety

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I am angry.

I've personally had first and secondhand accounts of women — no, girls — across the globe targeted by peers around them via artificial intelligence. This tool which should be utilized to advance technological achievements, aid in solving current global issues and democratize access to and promote knowledge has been exploited. A 2023 report showed that deepfake pornography made up 98 percent of all deepfake videos online and 99 percent depicted women (Panorama Global, 2023). It has become a method to bully, harass, and edit pornographic imagery of women.

While this has been a continuous issue in the world, especially after the introduction of Photoshop, AI has made this crime much more accessible and efficient. I've firsthand seen this happen to someone I know and felt rage — rage for the girl I barely knew experiencing this violation, rage for the random girl in India my cousin told me was dealing with a parallel situation. While it was not my place to press charges or confront the men (all computer science majors misusing their education and resources) I knew more than ever policies must be ameliorated around AI to prevent such crimes from occurring, or at least occurring with such ease. We also need stricter laws to enforce punishment for such heinous crimes. Due to the novelty and accessibility of this crime, any may view this as a “minor” act but the weight is quite heavy. According to recent research, more than half of deepfake victims contemplated suicide (UN Women, 2026).

This genre of crime has existed long before the evolution of AI, deepfakes and more. Image-based sexual abuse has taken several forms from Polaroid photographs shared without consent to hacked iCloud accounts. However, now the digital age has accelerated its reach and devastation exponentially (Panorama Global, 2026). Thus any laws which address image abuse leave large loopholes allowing exploitation with no regard for legal action. This goes beyond just the legalities of the issue. Deepfake abuse has affected employment, relationships, mental health and physical safety.

In more recent years countries are amending their laws but lack enforcement. The EU AI Act imposes transparency obligations around deepfakes. The United States passed the Take It Down Act, which explicitly covers AI-generated intimate imagery and requires platforms to remove content within 48 hours. In April 2025, Brazil amended its criminal code to increase penalties for psychological violence against women committed using AI. The UK's Online Safety Act prohibits sharing digitally manipulated explicit images however, it does not address the creation of deepfakes and may not apply where intent to cause distress cannot be proven. We lack true, efficient change to match the pace of artificial intelligence.

The men I know who did this are computer science majors who knew exactly what they were building, its effects and implementations. There was no concern for prosecution largely due to the novelty of this technology. This is not a gap in technical knowledge. This is a gap in policy, ethics and consequences.

Enforcement and prevention should be top priorities. This technology was created by us; it of course comes with pros and cons just like any other product or service, thus creating proper guidelines and governance around it is extremely important. We need actual laws addressing deepfakes, not just patchwork legislation built off existing image abuse frameworks, and we need them expedited. This is a fast-spreading issue and governance must match its pace. We must address these issues on a grander scale whether through international policy or strict global policies for all existing tech or AI organizations, because clearly current self-regulation is failing our society (Panorama, 2026).

I believe in creating AI policies mandating harm assessments specifically for misuse. The generation of deepfakes should be a lengthy process, especially one requiring strict frameworks requiring consent, authorization and perhaps even trails and tags so no one can hide behind anonymity. As a product designer I believe in delivering the best product. Meaning not just a product of high quality,

ethical integrity and social responsibility, but also one adhering to strict safety standards and accountability.

References

Panorama Global. (2023). *I didn't consent: A global landscape report on image-based sexual abuse*. Image-Based Sexual Abuse Initiative. [View report](#)

UN Women. (2026, February 26). *When justice fails: Why women can't get protection from AI deepfake abuse*. [Read article](#)

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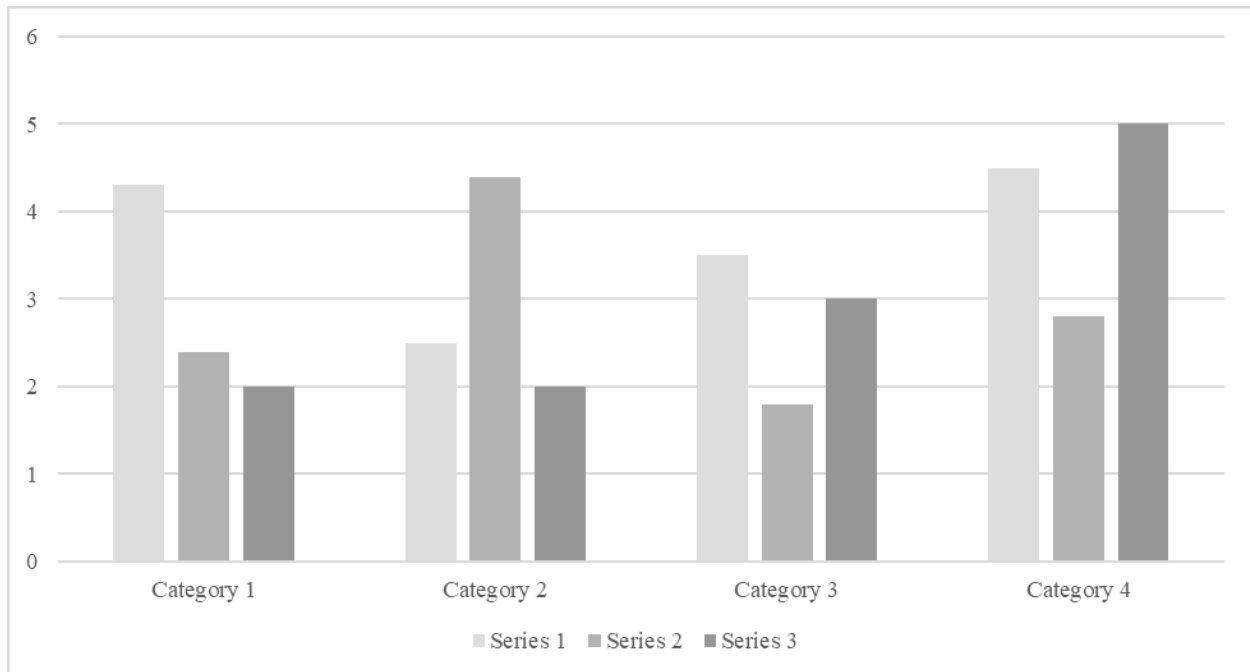
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